

Interview with Library Technology Administrator

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MLIS 4050: Library and Information Technologies

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October 13th, 2024

For this interview, I reached out to Joshua Hutchinson, who serves as the Director of Technical Services at USC (University of Southern California). Joshua graciously agreed to let me interview him, and though his title is not exactly the same as the assignment stipulated, his work has a significant overlap with management of library technology and digital infrastructure. Joshua received an MLIS from Aberystwyth University in Wales, UK. He has worked at USC for 4 years and prior to that spent many years working at UCLA (University of California, Los Angeles). He was recently promoted into his current position and told me that his title is still in the works, as he is not the director of all technical services. His department used to be combined with the acquisitions department, but due to recent budget cuts and the lack of new physical acquisitions, the digital and acquisition teams were split. The hierarchical or vertical structure of library departments is inconsistent between libraries and that is seen in practice here where even large intuitions struggle to know the best way to structure their staff.

USC has 22 libraries across the university and uses Primo for their ILS system. Joshua told me that his day-to-day job mainly consists of liaising between the technical team behind the scenes running the ILS and other library softwares, and with the patron-facing staff. His work ensures that the back end of the system is set up to meet the end user's needs. In addition to other duties, he submits one to two help tickets per week to update the administration of the ILS based on issues he learns about through his interactions with staff and his understanding of how those issues can be resolved within the system software.

Prior to Joshua working at USC, the university migrated to their current ILS and, according to Joshua, the migration went poorly. I was surprised to hear that they still had to constantly update the admin back end of the ILS so many years after migrating. Thinking back to what we learned about setting up an ILS in class, I thought most of that set up work is done at the

start of migration. Joshua said the poor migration was not the only reason they constantly needed to update it. Another reason is that their digital library systems are constantly updating and changing. The ILS or other software systems used may have a software or firmware update that, to make use of its new function, requires changing basic admin functions in the ILS set up profile.

It was also interesting to hear Joshua talk about the migration from their old ILS to their current one, even though it happened before he started working there. There are large groups of books that are cataloged in the system that are not actually in the library. This can lead to frustration for reference librarians and patrons who see a book in the system but cannot find it on shelves. There are also large groups of books that are on library shelves that are not cataloged at all. This is again a frustration for end users who are looking for these books but have no access point to find them. This is an ever present issue for the library catalogers and tech team at USC, and they have to prioritize where they spend their energy. Joshua shared that they might have a group of books that has mediocre metadata, and while they would like to update those records, they do need to focus their time on making sure they create metadata records for books that have no metadata at all.

Looking ahead, Joshua shared that the university's contract with Primo expires in about a year. He and his colleagues are just now starting to have conversations and think about if they want to renew with Primo or look for a new ILS system. When thinking about these decisions, whether it's a new ILS system, choosing ancillary softwares, or determining best practices for the library, he says he focuses more on "what is possible more than what is ideal". They might have an idea about how they would like their ILS to operate, or how they would prefer a system to be set up or organized, but if a system doesn't exist that can perform in the way they would like,

they must choose the best route that is actually possible to accomplish their goals within their given parameters. Academia can sometimes lean into the ideal and I appreciated this realistic perspective on the realities of implementing these systems and running technology departments.

Joshua cited an article that a former co-worker wrote called “Always Be Migrating” (McAuley, 2021). We have learned in class that creating RFP, and migrating to a new ILS, is a huge undertaking which entails many hours and months of planning and then many hours and months of training and transitioning to come to an ending point where you are settled into a new system. This article’s idea is conceptually about having a more fluid mindset about the systems that the library uses. The article encourages librarians to not think about new systems and migrating with an end goal in mind, but to understand that as soon as you migrate, you have to look forward to what new technologies are emerging and the next system or migration your library will require. This was a really fascinating point we discussed and opens up the mind to constantly be forecasting and forward thinking.

Looking ahead at new technologies, Joshua said he has been hearing that linked data and RDA are coming soon for a very long time, but it seems that soon is actually near this time. He and his colleagues are looking ahead at how to prepare for that transition. Some librarians are not very interested in training unless or until it affects the metadata that they currently input, and that others are more open to keeping ahead of the curve and always looking for what is new and how they can implement it. We chatted about how the latter of this scenario appears to foster an “always be migrating” mentality that will help keep technology transitions smooth for their library, while the former may struggle to keep up with transitions.

I shared with Joshua some of the articles we have discussed in this class, and I was surprised that he had not heard of Paul Otlet. I shared the articles we read in class with him, and I

am pleased I was able to impart some knowledge on someone who has been working in this profession for a number of years. Linked data is something they know is coming and want to prepare for, but until the technology is available to be demonstrated or to use, there is not much more they can do to prepare for it.

Joshua also shared that when interviewing candidates for jobs at USC, it can be frustrating that recent graduates have very little hands-on experience in library technologies. He seemed hopeful from hearing about this class and about this assignment that we are required to conduct this interview, that universities are moving toward curriculums that give their students relevant experience for finding jobs.

Overall, I really enjoyed interviewing Joshua and learning about his role at USC. It was helpful to learn about the thought processes that implement the technology in a large library system, as opposed to the theoretical framework we learn about in academia. This interview gave me a lot of context for how the ideas we've learned about in class are put into practice at a large institution.

Appendix

Interview Transcript – I was not able to retrieve the Zoom recording from DU MediaSpace, so I am not able to provide a transcript. Any notes I took or memory of the interview is included in the report.

References

Elizabeth McAulay. (2021). Always Be Migrating. *The Code4lib Journal*, 50.

<https://journal.code4lib.org/articles/15568>